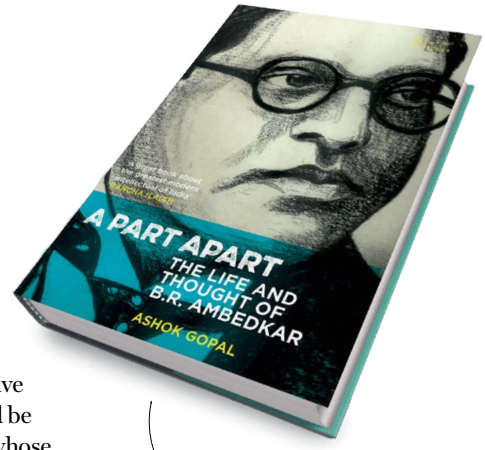
AL LIFE



A PART APART
The Life and Thought of B.R. Ambedkar
by Ashok Gopal
NAVAYANA
₹999; 864 pages

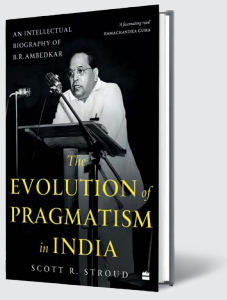
How could social democracy survive amidst caste bigotry? What would be the fate of minorities in a society whose moral and religious groundings rejected the principles of liberty, equality and fraternity? Ambedkar's answers were frank, bold and radical. What emerges in Gopal's book is a very different discovery of modern India. He told Gandhi and Nehru that their nationalist vision would merely entrench inequality: "Swarajya for whom and for what?" He told the orthodox that, far from being heirs to a glorious sanatan dharma and Indic culture, they were the enforcers of a vile medievalism.

Ambedkar's life was a search for alternatives. He scoured other intellectual traditions for insights on morality and democracy, but ultimately found the best embodiment in the Buddha. Gopal chronicles how Ambedkar's interest in Buddhism developed over decades and how it related to his earlier Hindu identity and attempts at social reform. Importantly, Gopal points out that Ambedkar did not simply craft the Buddha's teachings into a secularised ethical creed. Recognising the power of faith in India, he wanted Buddhism to be a lived religion for converts. It would replace Vedic strictures with an emotional attachment to the ideas of liberty, equality and fraternity. Only when these principles sank into the religious subconsciousness of India could there be a real chance of democracy.

One of the book's strengths is that, like its subject, it constantly questions and criticises. *A Part Apart* is far from being a hagiographical account. Ambedkar, Gopal tells us, could be a reluctant leader, something that occasionally stymied Dalit politics. Like his nationalist foes, he was an indifferent family man. While Ambedkar studied at Columbia, his long-suffering first wife Ramabai made cow-dung patties in Worli. He told his second wife Savita, "My books have been my companions; they are dearer to me than my wife and children." Ambedkar's politics could be profoundly inconsistent. He ensured widespread female participation in Dalit activism but, a day after his conversion in Nagpur, he excoriated Nehru for fielding so many women candidates for upcoming elections: "Who will take care of their children?"

These inconsistences also made Ambedkar a part apart. He read, forged opinions, read some more, and revised those opinions. As Gopal's biography makes clear, he had little tolerance for rigid ideology, instead crafting his politics on an unstinting defence of basic morality and human dignity. In this sense, *A Part Apart* is essential reading for all who wish to see a kinder, more egalitarian and more democratic India. ■

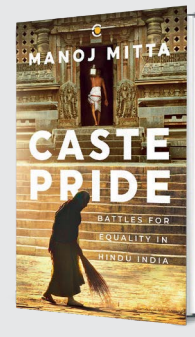
Dinyar Patel *teaches history at the S.P. Jain Institute of Management and Research in Mumbai*



THE EVOLUTION OF PRAGMATISM An intellectual biography of B.R. Ambedkar
by Scott R. Stroud
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599, 312 pages

Nothing so racy in this rather more high-minded account. The focus here is on Ambedkar's intellectual relationship with his Columbia professor, the American John Dewey, a leading light of the action-oriented and 'meliorist' school of pragmatist philosophy. This is a bookish account, but not as dry as you might expect. Illuminated with moments of archival discovery and a keen sense of how Ambedkar drew on his engagement with his American mentor but also pushed back critically as he forged his own path to 'Navayana Pragmatism'.

CASTE PRIDE
Battles for Equality in Hindu India
by Manoj Mitta
CONTEXT
₹999, 624 pages



This is no biography, but a study Ambedkar would likely have enthusiastically endorsed. Accessibly written and deeply researched, this book traces the intertwined threads of caste-related violence and conflict as well as legislation and social activism over some 200 years. Along the way, Mitta unravels the prejudices and power dynamics that course through modern India's justice system and celebrates a number of 'unsung heroes' who deserve their place in Ambedkar's cohort.